



The result? A spike in false shots. In 2025, the false shot percentage in overs 11–20 stands at 19 per cent — the highest in the last 15 years. This is a phase of play that has become quietly hostile, even as batters may perceive they’ve “seen off” the new ball.

Who’d be a number 3?

Few Test positions invite as much scrutiny — or as little reward — as

the number three. Ask Ollie Pope.

Since volunteering for the role under Ben Stokes despite minimal prior experience, Pope has become a lightning rod for criticism. His overall returns haven’t been poor, but they haven’t silenced doubts either.

He’s not alone. The No. 3 spot has become a revolving door across teams. In 2025, the average for number 3 batters is 32.32, with a

Sticky wicket: Another chapter, another challenge. Karun Nair at the crossroads of India’s ever-shifting No.3 puzzle. GETTY IMAGES